Yiqin Li

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PhD student at University College London, supervised by Zhibin Li. Interested in multimodal foundation models and low-latency visuomotor control for robust robot systems, and in world models and foundation models grounded in physical interaction.

Education

University College London, UK 10/2026 – Present

PhD student; supervised by Zhibin Li.

Imperial College London, UK 10/2021 – 07/2025

MEng Computing (Artificial Intelligence & Machine Learning) – First-class Honours

Coursework: Deep Learning, Computer Vision, Reinforcement Learning, NLP, Robotics, Robot Learning.

Shrewsbury School, UK 09/2016 – 06/2021

A Levels: Computer Science, Mathematics, Further Mathematics, Physics (all A*).

Research Experience & Projects

University College London, London 04/2026 – 10/2026

Research Assistant

RAI: Recursive Accelerated Imitation for Robot Manipulation

- Contributed to recursive imitation learning that trains successive robot policies on accelerated rollouts with targeted human corrections.
- Worked on XR teleoperation, multimodal data collection, contact-force estimation, and real-time chunked deployment connecting 30 Hz policy actions to 200 Hz arm control.
- The project achieved 92.3% mean full-trial success across four tasks versus 62.5% for teleoperation with the same architecture and episode count; a separate cyclic task reached 2.46× the seed policy's throughput.

Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Shanghai 12/2025 – 04/2026

Research Assistant under Professor Bo Zhao

Evo-SOTA – Open-Source VLA Benchmark Leaderboard (GitHub, Website)

- Built and maintained an open-source VLA leaderboard with interactive metric tables, visualisations, and paper/code links; now covers eight benchmarks and has 160+ GitHub stars.

Dexterous-Hand VLA Pipeline

- Built a real-robot data-collection system integrating LinkerHand O6, xArm6, and a UDCAP glove using ROS2 and UDP, with a stable logging pipeline for dexterous manipulation.
- Adapted Evo-1 for dexterous manipulation and established an end-to-end pipeline from demonstration collection and training to simulation/real-robot inference and evaluation.

Language-Guided Imitation Learning for Tabletop Manipulation 12/2024 – 05/2025

MEng Thesis, supervised by Professor Edward Johns (Thesis, Demo)

- Built an LLM planner and behaviour-tree controller for multi-step tabletop manipulation, combining task decomposition, policy execution, and automatic failure recovery.
- Extended DINOBot to multi-task imitation learning in PyBullet with a Franka Panda; built an interface for non-expert users to clarify commands and teach new behaviours through demonstrations.
- In a controlled user study, achieved 100% pick-and-place and 65.8% multi-step success with recovery, 2.4× the zero-shot baseline; system mental demand was 1.0/7 (NASA-TLX).

Professional Experience

Thomson Reuters Labs, London 06/2025 – 12/2025

Applied Scientist Intern

- **Agentic systems.** Developed capabilities for Westlaw Deep Research Agent; owned the guardrail subsystem for query-intent classification and policy routing.
- **Model fine-tuning and benchmarking.** Compared prompt-only baselines, proprietary models, and LoRA-tuned Qwen3 8B/14B for guardrail classification; applied data augmentation, probability calibration, and precision–recall threshold selection.
- **Evaluation infrastructure.** Enhanced an internal spaCy-based NLP pipeline converting LLM-generated answers into structured representations; evaluated five agent iterations using answer completeness and misattribution metrics to guide development.

Huawei, London 04/2024 – 09/2024

NLP Researcher Intern

- **Knowledge graphs.** Built an LLM-based graph-construction pipeline on GPU clusters, generating domain-specific graphs with 30K+ nodes deployed in Huawei Browser; acknowledged in a Findings of ACL 2025 paper (PDF).
- **Data engineering.** Developed a production pipeline using Pydantic and Pandas to convert unstructured LLM-generated graphs into schema-aligned records, improving data integrity and maintainability.
- **NLP tooling.** Built a RAG/LLM pipeline for character-relation and attribute extraction, and an N-gram NER validation module for Huawei Reading; improved NER accuracy by 15%+ on held-out tests.

Shanghai Wicresoft, Shanghai 07/2023 – 08/2023

Big Data Engineer Intern

- **Knowledge graph and QA.** Built a Neo4j graph (10K nodes, 40K edges) and a rule-based pipeline converting unstructured legal clauses into structured records at approximately 90% conversion for an AI-driven QA system.
- **Data processing.** Processed and cleaned 40,000+ entries to support model training and evaluation; developed a graph-access API for internal analysts.

Honours & Awards

- First place, Fitch Group Code for Good Codeathon
- UKIEPC 2023, Top 100
- Runner-up, Ripple X EasyA Hackathon

Technical Skills

- **Programming:** Python, Kotlin, C, Haskell, SQL
- **Robot learning:** Imitation learning, flow-matching policies, real-time action chunking, human-in-the-loop data collection, multimodal policy deployment
- **Robotics and simulation:** ROS2, PyBullet, Isaac Sim/Lab, MuJoCo, XR teleoperation
- **ML and data:** PyTorch, LoRA, spaCy, Pydantic, Pandas, Neo4j
- **Languages:** English and Mandarin (fluent)

Interests

Basketball (Imperial College Men's 1st Team), rock climbing, mountaineering (Kilimanjaro summit).